

# Strengthening Governance and Advancing Public Service Professionalisation

Department of Public Service and Administration (DPSA)

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# Introduction

Refers to improving the systems, structures, and processes that regulate the relationship between government employers and public sector employees (and their unions).

Strong governance ensures fairness, accountability, transparency and effective service delivery

A critical point for reflection in this session is the interdependence between governance, professionalisation and labour relations outcomes.

- **Sound governance** provides the structure, rules, and accountability within which labour relations must operate.
- **Professionalisation** ensures that public servants have the competence and ethical grounding to apply those rules correctly.
- **Stable labour relations** are an outcome of both strong governance and professional conduct.



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- Where governance frameworks are weak, inconsistent, or poorly enforced, labour relations often become adversarial, reactive, and unstable. Conversely, where public servants lack the appropriate skills, ethical grounding, and professional standards, even well designed governance frameworks fail to deliver intended outcomes.
- This discussion therefore seeks to explore **how sound governance arrangements, ethical conduct, accountability mechanisms and continuous skills development can collectively enhance institutional capacity and improve labour relations outcomes** across the public service.



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# DISCUSSION

Public service institutions operate within a complex environment characterised by:

- Increasing service delivery expectations from citizens;
- Heightened scrutiny of governance, ethics and accountability;
- Ongoing labour relations challenges, including grievances, disputes and implementation gaps; and
- Skills shortages and limited professional capacity at managerial and operational levels.

In many instances, labour relations challenges are symptoms of deeper governance and capability issues, such as:

- Unclear decision making authority;
- Inconsistent application of labour policies and collective agreements;
- Limited managerial competence in handling people and labour matters;
- Weak accountability and consequence management; and
- Insufficient investment in structured skills development.



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# Establishing Clear Legal and Policy Frameworks

- Ensure labour laws and public service regulations are aligned.
- Clearly define roles and responsibilities of government departments, bargaining councils and unions.
- Promote compliance with constitutional principles, labour legislation and collective agreements.
- Regularly review policies to address emerging labour issues.

- Transparent processes for handling grievances, disputes, and disciplinary matters; and
- Effective accountability and consequence management for non compliance.

It is important to acknowledge that weak governance increases mistrust, fuels disputes and undermines stability, whereas predictable and transparent governance promotes confidence and cooperation between the employer and labour.

# Enhancing Institutional Capacity

- Strengthen the capacity of HR and labour relations units in government departments.
- Provide continuous training for managers, union representatives and labour relations practitioners.
- Develop standardised operating procedures for handling disputes and negotiations.
- Use data and workforce analysis to inform labour strategies.

# A professionalised public service is one in which:

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- Appointments are based on merit, competence and ethical standards;
- Public servants possess the skills and behavioural competencies required for their roles;
- Managers are equipped to lead people, manage conflict and apply labour policies fairly; and
- Continuous learning and development are embedded as organisational norms.

# Promoting Transparency and Accountability

- Improve position papers and communication during collective bargaining processes.
- Ensure transparent wage negotiation processes supported by credible financial data.
- Introduce monitoring and evaluation mechanisms for implementing agreements.
- Establish performance indicators linked to labour stability and service delivery.

# Improving Collective Bargaining Systems

- Encourage structured and good-faith negotiations.
- Develop multi-year wage agreements to enhance predictability and fiscal planning.
- Strengthen dispute resolution mechanisms (mediation, arbitration, conciliation).
- Promote problem-solving approaches rather than adversarial engagements.

# Strengthening Ethical Leadership and Integrity

- Promote ethical conduct among public officials and union leaders.
- Implement anti-corruption safeguards in recruitment, promotions, and disciplinary processes.
- Enforce conflict-of-interest directives.
- Encourage a culture of professionalism and mutual respect.

# Building Trust and Social Dialogue

- Institutionalise regular consultation forums beyond wage negotiations.
- Encourage collaboration on workforce planning, service delivery reforms, and productivity improvement.
- Foster mutual trust through transparency and consistent communication.

# Monitoring and Continuous Improvement

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- Conduct periodic audits of labour relations systems.
- Evaluate the impact of labour agreements on service delivery.
- Benchmark against international best practices (e.g., ILO standards).
- Encourage feedback mechanisms from employees and citizens.

# Expected Outcomes of Strong Governance

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- Reduced labour disputes and strike action
- Improved public sector productivity
- Enhanced service delivery
- Greater fiscal sustainability
- Increased public trust in government



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# Emerging Challenges and Risks

- Fragmentation between HR, labour relations, training and organisational development functions;
- Reliance on reactive, dispute-driven approaches rather than preventative strategies;
- Capacity constraints, especially at supervisory and middle management levels;
- Inconsistent enforcement of accountability and consequence management; and
- Change resistance and limited buy-in from key stakeholders.

# Conclusion

In closing, this session provides an opportunity to reaffirm that effective governance and professionalisation are the foundation to a stable, ethical and high performing public service.

Strengthening labour relations outcomes is not only a compliance exercise but a strategic imperative for sustaining institutional credibility, employee morale and service delivery effectiveness.



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# Thank You



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